MODULE 5: INTERPERSONAL SKILLS & LEADERSHIP/ NEGOTIATION CASE STUDIES

(CO: 6 | Weightage: 30 Marks in FAT — Questions 8, 9 & 10)

Belbin 9 Roles, Leadership Case Study Architecture, BATNA & TKI Conflict Mastery

Aligned with Official VIT BAENG101 Syllabus, School of Social Sciences & Languages Question Bank, and FAT Papers

Scope of This Module (Official Syllabus & FAT Blueprint):
(1) Interpersonal Communication dynamics & Transactional Analysis, (2) The Nine Belbin Team Roles (Action, People, and Thought domains), (3) Leadership Styles & Case Study Framework (Autocratic, Democratic, Transformational, Laissez-faire), (4) Negotiation Skills: Fisher & Ury Principled Negotiation, BATNA, Reservation Price, and ZOPA, (5) Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI) 2D Grid.
NOTE ON EXCLUSIONS: Statement of Purpose (SOP) is strictly excluded from the FAT paper.

1 1. VIT FAT Exam Blueprint: Questions 8, 9 & 10 Breakdown (30 Marks!)

Module 5 dominates the second half of your 100-mark FAT paper, carrying a decisive **30 Marks**:

Question	Exam Focus	Exact Testing Requirements & Rubric	Marks
Question 8	Interpersonal Communication & Belbin Roles	Explain the 9 Belbin Team Roles across their 3 clusters (Action, People, Thought); analyze how team role imbalances cause project delays or failures in engineering teams.	10 Marks
Question 9	Case Study on Leadership Styles	A detailed corporate/engineering crisis narrative is presented. You must: (1) Diagnose executive leadership failure, (2) Cite evidence from the case, and (3) Prescribe an appropriate leadership turnaround model.	10 Marks
Question 10	Case Study on Negotiation Skills & Conflict	A supplier/contract deadlock scenario is given. You must calculate and define BATNA, formulate principled win-win options, and apply the Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument.	10 Marks

2 2. The Nine Belbin Team Roles: Master Classification Table

Dr. Meredith Belbin demonstrated that high-performing engineering teams do not rely simply on technical brilliance, but require a balanced distribution of nine distinct behavioral roles clustered into three domains:

Cluster	Belbin Role	Core Strength & Contribution	Allowable Weakness (VIT Exam Rule)
Action-Oriented	**Shaper**	Challenging, dynamic, thrives under pressure. Has drive and courage to overcome obstacles.	Prone to provocation, short-tempered, may offend colleagues' feelings in the drive to finish.
	Implementer	Practical, reliable, disciplined. Turns concepts into workable operational workflows.	Somewhat inflexible; slow to respond to unproven disruptive innovations.
	Completer Finisher	Painstaking, conscientious, perfectionist. Searches for errors, polish deliverables.	Inclined to worry unduly; reluctant to delegate small tasks; micromanages.

People-Oriented	**Coordinator**	Mature, confident leader. Clarifies goals, promotes decision-making, delegates well.	Can be seen as manipulative; offloads personal work onto others.
	Teamworker	Cooperative, diplomatic, perceptive. Listens, calms friction, builds team cohesion.	Indecisive in acute crunch moments; avoids interpersonal confrontation.
	Resource Investigator	Extroverted, enthusiastic, communicative. Explores outside opportunities, contacts.	Over-optimistic initially; rapidly loses momentum once initial excitement cools.
Thought-Oriented	**Plant**	Creative, imaginative, unorthodox. Generates disruptive solutions to complex problems.	Ignores operational protocols; too preoccupied to communicate effectively with mortals.
	Monitor Evaluator	Sober, strategic, discerning. Judges all options objectively without emotional bias.	Lacks drive and ability to inspire others; overly critical of novel ideas.
	Specialist	Single-minded, dedicated, self-starting. Delivers rare technical knowledge in depth.	Contributes only on a narrow front; dwells on technical minutiae at the expense of big picture.

3 3. Leadership Styles: Comparative Framework & Case Study Method

3.1 3.1 The 4 Dominant Leadership Archetypes

1. **Autocratic (Authoritarian):** Centralized decision-making, strict top-down directives, zero employee consultation. **Effective in:** Immediate physical emergencies, factory fire evacuations, acute safety cutoffs. **Disastrous in:** Creative software architecture, research teams (erodes psychological safety, triggers resignations).
2. **Democratic (Participative):** Encourages team input, consensus building, transparent deliberation. **Effective in:** Engineering design reviews, complex problem solving. **Disastrous in:** Urgent real-time crises requiring split-second decisions.
3. **Transformational:** Visionary, articulates an inspiring purpose, fosters intellectual stimulation, mentors talent. **Effective in:** Corporate turnarounds, technological modernization, agile restructuring.
4. **Laissez-Faire (Delegative):** Hands-off approach, leaves complete autonomy to subordinates. **Effective in:** Highly specialized R&D institutes with autonomous PhD scientists. **Disastrous in:** Teams with junior engineers needing clear milestones and guidance.

3.2 3.2 The 4-Step Case Study Solution Template for Question 9

To score a full 10/10 in Question 9, structure your answer using these four explicit headings:

- **Heading 1: Problem Identification:** State the underlying organizational bottleneck and employee friction points.
- **Heading 2: Theoretical Diagnosis:** Identify the leadership style exhibited (e.g. "Rigid Autocratic Leadership"), defining its characteristics.
- **Heading 3: Evidence from Text:** Quote specific sentences from the prompt demonstrating the pathology (e.g. cancelled leaves, public reprimands, suppressed feedback).
- **Heading 4: Actionable Remediation Plan:** Prescribe the alternative leadership model (e.g. Transformational / Situational) with a 3-step turnaround roadmap.

4 4. Negotiation Skills & Conflict Resolution Frameworks

4.1 4.1 Principled Negotiation (Fisher & Ury Model)

1. **Separate the People from the Problem:** Attack the technical issue, not the individuals.
2. **Focus on Underlying Interests, Not Positional Stances:** Positions are what people say they want; interests are why they want it.
3. **Invent Options for Mutual Gain (Expand the Pie):** Brainstorm creative trade-offs before deciding.
4. **Insist on Objective Standards:** Benchmark negotiations against independent market indexes, engineering standards, or legal precedent.

4.2 4.2 BATNA, Reservation Price & ZOPA

- **BATNA (Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement):** The fallback action a party will take if talks collapse completely. **BATNA determines your power:** A negotiator with an exceptional BATNA cannot be bullied into bad terms!
- **Reservation Price:** The absolute walk-away threshold (the worst deal acceptable before triggering BATNA).
- **ZOPA (Zone of Possible Agreement):** The overlap region between the buyer's maximum ceiling and seller's minimum floor.

4.3 4.3 The Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI)

Classifies conflict behaviors along two independent axes:

- **Assertiveness:** Extent to which an individual attempts to satisfy their own concerns.
- **Cooperativeness:** Extent to which an individual attempts to satisfy the other party's concerns.

Conflict Mode	Axis Coordinates	Engineering Application & Stance
Competing	High Assertiveness, Low Cooperativeness	"My way." Decisive emergency action; vital when safety standards or legal compliance are at stake.
Collaborating	High Assertiveness, High Cooperativeness	"Our way." Win-win integrative solution; essential for cross-functional hardware/software co-design.
Compromising	Moderate Assertiveness, Moderate Cooperativeness	"Halfway." Both parties trade concessions to reach a quick expedient operational settlement.
Avoiding	Low Assertiveness, Low Cooperativeness	"No way." Sidestepping trivial issues or allowing heated emotional confrontations to cool down.
Accommodating	Low Assertiveness, High Cooperativeness	"Your way." Yielding to the other perspective when preserving client relationships outweighs short-term gain.

5 5. Worked FAT Past Papers & Model 10-Mark Case Studies

5.1 Problem 5.1: Full FAT Question 9 Case Study Solved (10 Marks)

Prompt: Rajesh, the newly appointed VP of an aerospace manufacturing firm, discovers that the assembly line is 3 weeks behind schedule on a major defense contract. He cancels all weekend leaves, mandates 14-hour daily shifts, issues public reprimands to supervisors during morning meetings, and states: "My instructions are final; do not question the schedule." Within two weeks, three senior quality inspectors resign, and defect rates in machined turbine components increase by 28%. (a) Identify the leadership style exhibited by Rajesh and explain why it failed. (b) Propose and justify an alternative leadership turnaround model.

Model 10/10 Answer:

1. Problem Identification:
The manufacturing plant suffers from severe operational backlogs compounded by an acute collapse in workforce morale, resulting in high attrition of mission-critical quality inspectors and an alarming 28% escalation in manufacturing defects.

2. Theoretical Diagnosis of Exhibited Leadership Style:
Rajesh exhibits a classic **Rigid Autocratic (Authoritarian)** leadership style characterized by unilateral command, coercive overtime mandates, public humiliation, and complete suppression of bottom-up technical communication.

3. Evidence and Analysis of Why it Failed:
- **Suppression of Psychological Safety:** Public reprimands created an atmosphere of fear. Workers concealed machine calibration flaws to avoid punitive wrath, directly causing the 28% defect surge.
- **Brain Drain of Specialized Talent:** Aerospace inspection requires scarce domain expertise; autocratic bullying precipitated the resignation of three senior inspectors whose loss paralyses quality audits.
- **Failure to Diagnose Root Causes:** A 3-week delay in aerospace manufacturing typically originates from supply chain part shortages or machine tool wear, rather than worker laziness. Coercive pressure exacerbated rather than resolved the mechanical bottleneck.

4. Alternative Leadership Turnaround Model: Transformational & Consultative Leadership:
Rajesh must immediately pivot to a **Transformational and Situational Leadership** model:
- **Action 1: All-Hands Strategic Alignment:** Convene a transparent town hall communicating the national significance of the defense contract, inspiring shared commitment rather than instilling fear.
- **Action 2: Root-Cause Technical Hackathon:** Assemble machine supervisors and technicians to diagnose production chokepoints using Ishikawa (fishbone) diagrams to identify the true bottlenecks.
- **Action 3: Incentive-Driven Scheduling:** Replace punitive mandatory overtime with voluntary split-shifts compensated with overtime bonuses and compensatory off-days once defense delivery milestones are secured.

5.2 Problem 5.2: Full FAT Question 10 Negotiation Case Study Solved (10 Marks)

Prompt: ElectroDrive, an EV startup, is negotiating a battery supply contract with PowerCell Corp. PowerCell demands USD 110 per kWh with an upfront non-refundable tooling charge of USD 2 Million. ElectroDrive's budget target is USD 95 per kWh with a maximum ceiling of USD 102 per kWh. Negotiations stall as both sides engage in positional bargaining. (a) Define BATNA and determine what ElectroDrive's BATNA should be before re-entering talks. (b) Using Fisher & Ury's Principled Negotiation, demonstrate how ElectroDrive can break the deadlock.

Model 10/10 Answer:

Part (a) BATNA Definition & Determination:

- **Definition:** BATNA (Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement) is the most advantageous course of action a negotiating party can execute if ongoing talks collapse completely. It establishes the objective reservation threshold below which no agreement should be signed.
- **ElectroDrive's BATNA:** Prior to resuming negotiations, ElectroDrive must obtain a firm, validated alternative supply quote (e.g., from an alternate manufacturer like Apex Battery at USD 104/kWh, or initiating an in-house pack assembly pilot). Possessing a validated USD 104/kWh backup establishes a credible reservation boundary, preventing PowerCell from coercing them into their USD 110/kWh demand.

Part (b) Breaking the Deadlock via Principled Negotiation:

1. Separate the People from the Problem: Refrain from accusing PowerCell of extortion. Reframe the discussion from a combative tug-of-war into a collaborative engineering venture.

2. Focus on Underlying Interests, Not Rigid Positions:

- **PowerCell's Position:** "USD 110/kWh + USD 2M upfront." **Underlying Interest:** Cash flow security and hedging against volatile global lithium/nickel commodity spikes.
- **ElectroDrive's Position:** "USD 95/kWh." **Underlying Interest:** Preserving vehicle gross margins while guaranteeing scheduled multi-year delivery.

3. Invent Options for Mutual Gain (Expanding the Pie):

- **Index-Linked Pricing:** Establish a baseline price of USD 98/kWh tied dynamically to the London Metal Exchange lithium carbonate spot index, mitigating PowerCell's commodity risk.
- **Tooling Amortization:** Offer to amortize the USD 2M tooling cost across the first 50,000 delivered battery packs (USD 40 per pack) rather than paying a lump-sum deposit.
- **Volume Tier Commitments:** Guarantee exclusive battery supply rights for ElectroDrive's upcoming commercial delivery van line in exchange for immediate price concessions.

4. Insist on Objective Standards: Benchmark contract rates against the current BloombergNEF industry volume weighted average (USD 100/kWh) to achieve an equitable, data-driven agreement within the ZOPA.